I set up the model by the foyer of Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre, a place nobody visiting the centre, including the chairman, could avoid. I got a platform built around the upper part of the engine, and a stair case leading up to it, so that one can touch, feel and see the parts of the gas generator, the turbo pump and the feed lines. At the foot of engine sat a board that read: 'I am Vikas engine. I have a thrust of sixty tonnes and my specific impulse is 295 seconds. By the way, I am an orphan.'

I was in great pain when I wrote the word 'orphan'. Not just because I was displaying the result of my toil as a fatherless child, but to call Vikas an orphan was like turning a dagger inside me. And here is letting you into one of my best kept secrets—something which even some ISRO chairmen would find new. While the French had already named their engine Viking, I decided, at the time of drafting the contract itself, to give it an Indian name.

Vikas means development in Sanskrit, and this was easy to sell within ISRO as a nomenclature, but I had seen another adapted anagram in the name. For me, Vikas stood for Vikram A Sarabhai. I shared this only with Seshan, who readily agreed, but he advised me to keep it to myself. Not because anyone would challenge the genius of Sarabhai—just that I did not want to go through the bureaucratic process of approvals ISRO was infamous for, especially when it came to naming projects and centres after a person.

So, as Vikas stood at the foyer, VSSC employees stopped to take a close look, then read the board. Some frowned, some smirked. All I cared for was Dhawan's reaction. And that came soon. On his way to the conference room, Dhawan paused at Vikas, admired the model and then read the board before walking away. I was disappointed. But not for long. At lunch break, Dhawan took me aside. I knew what was coming.

'So, why is Vikas an orphan?' he asked.

'Because it is one,' I replied. "Because even after developing the engine, we don't have a project to fabricate and test Vikas."

Dhawan did not pause to say: 'How much money would you need to make a real, working engine?'

'Rs 60 lakh.'